



Guide to First Person, Second Person, and Third Person POV

By **Joe Bunting** · 80 Comments

In my experience as an editor, point of view problems are among the top mistakes I see new writers make, and they instantly erode credibility and reader trust. Point of view isn't easy though, since there are so many to choose from: first person point of view, third person limited, third person omniscient, and second person.

What do those even mean? And how do you choose the right one for your story?



All stories are written from a point of view. However, when point of view goes wrong—and believe me, it goes wrong often—you threaten whatever trust you have with your reader. You also fracture their suspension of disbelief.

However, point of view is simple to master if you use common sense.

This post will define point of view, go over each of the major POVs, explain a few of the POV rules, and then point out the major pitfalls writers make when dealing with that point of view.

Need help with point of view? To get a cheatsheet of the two most common POVs used in fiction, [click here](#).



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Point of View Definition

The point of view, or POV, in a story is the narrator's position in the description of events, and comes from the Latin word,

Note that point of view also has a second definition.

In a discussion, an argument, or [nonfiction writing](#), a point of view is an opinion about a subject. This is not the type of point of view we're going to focus on in this article (although it is helpful for nonfiction writers, and for more information, I recommend checking out [Wikipedia's neutral point of view policy](#)).

I especially like the German word for POV, which is *Gesichtspunkt*, translated “face point,” or where your face is pointed. Isn't that a good visual for what's involved in point of view? It's the limited perspective of what you show your reader.

Note, too, that point of view is sometimes called narrative mode or narrative perspective.

Why Point of View Is So Important

Why does point of view matter so much?

For a fiction writer, point of view filters *everything* in your story. Everything in your story must come from a point of view.

Which means if you get it wrong, your entire story is damaged.

twenty percent of them. Many of these stories would have placed much higher if only the writers hadn't made the mistakes we're going to talk about soon.

The worst part is these mistakes are easily avoidable if you're aware of them. But before we get into the common point of view mistakes, let's go over each of the four types of narrative perspective.

The Four Types of Point of View

Here are the four primary types of narration in fiction:

- **First person point of view.** First person perspective is when “I” am telling the story. The first person POV character is *in* the story, relating his or her experiences directly.
- **Second person point of view.** The story is told to “you.” This POV is not common in fiction, but it's still good to know (it *is* common in nonfiction).
- **Third person point of view, limited.** The story is about “he” or “she.” This is the most common point of view in commercial fiction. The narrator is outside of the story and relating the experiences of a character.
- **Third person point of view, omniscient.** The story is still about “he” or “she,” but the narrator has full access to the thoughts and

POINT OF VIEW PRONOUNS

You can determine the point of view of a story by the pronouns the narrator uses to describe the central character(s).

I, ME, MY

First
Person

SHE/HE, HER/HIS

Third
Person

YOU, YOUR

Second
Person

 The Write Practice

I know you've seen and probably even used most of these point of views.

While these are the only types of POV, there are additional narrative techniques you can use to tell an interesting story. To learn how to use devices like epistolary and framing stories, check out [our full narrative devices guide here](#).

Let's discuss each of the four types, using [examples to see how they affect your story](#). We'll also go over the rules for each type, but first let me explain the big mistake you don't want to make with point of view.

The #1 POV Mistake

Once you pick a point of view, you're stuck with it.

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Do not begin your story with a first person narrator and then switch to a third person narrator. Do not start with third person limited point of view and then abruptly give your narrator full omniscience. This is the most common type of error I see writers make with point of view.

The guideline I learned in my first [creative writing class in college](#) is a good one:



Establish the point of view within the first two paragraphs of your story.

And above all, [don't change your point of view](#). If you do, it creates a jarring experience for the reader and you'll threaten your reader's trust. You could even fracture the architecture of your story.

That being said, as long as you're consistent, you can sometimes get away with using multiple POV types. This isn't easy and isn't recommended, but for example, one of my favorite stories, a 7,000-

way, if you're looking for a novel to read over the next two to six months, I highly recommend it—here's the link to read [for free online](#).) The first time the author switched point of views, he nearly lost my trust. However, he kept this dual-POV consistent over 7,000 pages and made it work.

Whatever point of view choices you make, be consistent. Your readers will thank you!

Now, let's go into detail on each of the four narrative perspective types, their best practices, and mistakes to avoid.

First Person Point of View

In first person point of view, the narrator is *in* the story and telling the events he or she is personally experiencing.

The simplest way to understand first person is that the narrative will use first-person pronouns, like I, me, and my.

Here's a first person point of view example from Herman Melville's *Moby Dick*:



Call me Ishmael. Some years ago—never mind how long precisely—having little or no money in my purse, and nothing particular to



First person narrative perspective is one of the most common POVs in fiction. If you haven't read a book in first person point of view, you haven't been reading.

What makes this point of view interesting, and challenging, is that all of the events in the story are filtered through the narrator and explained in his or her own unique narrative voice.

This means first person narrative is both biased and incomplete, but it can also deliver a level of intimacy other POVs can't.

Other first person point of view examples can be found in these popular novels:

- *The Sun Also Rises* by [Ernest Hemingway](#)
- *Twilight* by Stephenie Meyer
- *Ready Player One* by Ernest Cline
- *The Hunger Games* by Suzanne Collins
- *The Great Gatsby* by F. Scott Fitzgerald
- *Jane Eyre* by Charlotte Brönte

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First Person Narrative is Unique to Writing

There's no such thing as first person in film or theater—although voiceovers and mockumentary interviews like the ones in *The Office* and *Modern Family* provide a level of first person narrative in third person perspective film and television.

In fact, the very first novels were written in first person, modeled after popular journals and autobiographies which were first-person stories of nonfiction.

First Person Point of View is Limited

First person narrators are narrated from a single character's perspective at a time. They cannot be everywhere at once and thus cannot get all sides of the story.

They are telling *their* story, not necessarily *the* story.

First Person Point of View is Biased

flaws.

Of course, this is why we love first person narrative, because it's imbued with the central character's personality and their unique perspective on the world.

The most extreme use of this bias is called an unreliable narrator. **Unreliable narration** is a technique used by novelists to surprise the reader by capitalizing on the limitations of first person narration to make the narrator's version of events extremely prejudicial to their side and/or highly separated from reality.

You'll notice this form of narration being used when you, as the reader or audience, discover that you can't trust the narrator.

For example, Gillian Flynn's *Gone Girl* pits two unreliable narrators against one another. Each relates their conflicting version of events, one through typical narration and the other through journal entries. Another example is *Fight Club*, in which *SPOILER* the narrator has a split personality and imagines another character who drives the plot.

Other Interesting Uses of First Person Narrative:

- The classic novel *Heart of Darkness* is actually a first person narrative within a first person narrative. The narrator recounts verbatim the story Charles Marlow tells about his trip up the Congo river while they sit at port in England.

story is a third person account of Thomas Sutpen, his grandfather, as told to Quentin by Rosa Coldfield. Yes, it's just as complicated as it sounds!

- Salman Rushdie's award-winning *Midnight's Children* is told in first person, but spends most of the first several hundred pages giving a precise third person account of the narrator's ancestors. It's still first person, just a first person narrator telling a story about someone else.

Two Big Mistakes Writers Make with First Person Point of View

When writing in first person, there are two major mistakes writers make:

1. The narrator isn't likable. Your protagonist doesn't have to be a cliché hero. She doesn't even need to be good. However, she *must* be *interesting*.

The audience will not stick around for 300 pages listening to a character they don't enjoy. This is one reason why anti-heroes make great first person narrators.

They may not be morally perfect, but they're almost always interesting. (Remember Holden Caulfield in *The Catcher in the Rye*?)

explaining what he's thinking and how he feels about the situation.

You're allowed to mention the character's mood, but don't forget that your reader's trust and attention relies on what your character does, not what he thinks about doing.

Second Person Point of View

While not used often in fiction—it is used regularly in nonfiction, song lyrics, and even video games—second person POV is still helpful to understand.

In this point of view, the narrator relates the experiences using second person pronouns, like you and your. Thus, *you* become the protagonist, *you* carry the plot, and *your* fate determines the story.

We've written elsewhere about [why you should try writing in second person](#), but in short we like second person narration because it:

- Pulls the reader into the action of the story
- Makes the story personal
- Surprises the reader
- Stretches your skills as a writer

Here's an example from the breakout bestseller *Bright Lights, Big City* by Jay McInerney (probably the most popular example that



You have friends who actually care about you and speak the language of the inner self. You have avoided them of late. Your soul is as disheveled as your apartment, and until you can clean it up a little you don't want to invite anyone inside.

Second person narration isn't used frequently, however there are some notable examples of it.

Some other novels that use second person point of view are:

- Remember the *Choose Your Own Adventure* series? If you've ever read one of these novels where you get to decide the fate of the character (I always killed my character, unfortunately), you've read second person narrative.
- *The Fifth Season* by N.K. Jemison
- The opening of *The Night Circus* by Erin Morgenstern

There are also many experimental novels and short stories that use second person, and writers such as William Faulkner, Nathaniel Hawthorne, and Albert Camus played with the style.

Breaking the Fourth Wall

Night's Dream, Puck says:



*If we shadows have offended, think but this, and all is mended,
that you have but slumbered here while these visions did appear.*

This narrative device of speaking directly to the audience or the reader is called breaking the fourth wall (the other three walls being the setting of the story).

To think of it another way, it's a way the writer can briefly use second person in a first or third person narrative.

It's a lot of fun! You should try it.

Third Person Point of View

In third person narration, the narrator is outside of the story and relating the experiences of a character.

The central character is not the narrator. In fact, the narrator is not present in the story at all.

The simplest way to understand third person narration is that it uses third-person pronouns, like he/she, his/hers, and they/theirs.

Third Person Omniscient

The all-knowing narrator has full access to *all* the thoughts and experiences of *all* the characters in the story.

Examples of Third Person Omniscient:

While much less common today, third person omniscient narration was once the predominant type, used by most classic authors. Here are some of the novels using omniscient perspective today.

- *War and Peace* by Leo Tolstoy
- *Middlemarch* by George Eliot
- *Where the Crawdads Sing* by Delia Owens
- *The Old Man and the Sea* by Ernest Hemingway
- *Still Life* by Louise Penny (and all the Inspector Gamache series, which is amazing, by the way)
- *Gossip Girl* by Cecily von Ziegesar
- *Strange the Dreamer* by Laini Taylor
- *Little Women* by Louisa May Alcott
- *Crazy Rich Asians* by Kevin Kwan (one of my favorites!)

... and ... by Jane Austen

- [More third person omniscient examples can be found here](#)

Third Person Limited

The narrator has only some, if any, access to the thoughts and experiences of the characters in the story, often just to [one character](#).

Examples of Third Person Limited

Here's an example of a third person limited narrator from *Harry Potter and the Sorcerer's Stone* by J.K. Rowling:

A breeze ruffled the neat hedges of Privet Drive, which lay silent and tidy under the inky sky, the very last place you would expect astonishing things to happen. Harry Potter rolled over inside his blankets without waking up. One small hand closed on the letter beside him and he slept on, not knowing he was special, not knowing he was famous.... He couldn't know that at this very moment, people meeting in secret all over the country were holding up their glasses and saying in hushed voices: "To Harry Potter—the boy who lived!"

- *Game of Thrones* series by George R.R. Martin (this has an ensemble cast, but Martin stays in one character's point of view at a time, making it a clear example of limited POV with multiple viewpoint characters, which we'll talk about in just a moment)
- *For Whom the Bell Tolls* by Ernest Hemingway
- *The Way of Kings* by Brandon Sanderson
- *The Da Vinci Code* by [Dan Brown](#)
- *The Girl with the Dragon Tattoo* by Stieg Larsson
- *Ulysses* by James Joyce
- *Love in the Time of Cholera* by Gabriel Garcia Marquez
- *1984* by George Orwell
- *Orphan Train* by Christina Baker Kline
- *Fates and Furies* by Lauren Groff

Should You Use Multiple Viewpoint Characters vs. a Single Perspective?

One feature of third person limited and first person narrative is that you have the option of having multiple viewpoint characters.